CRACK THE REFORM CODE

Educational reform is unfinished business. More resources and full adoption of NEP are a must to end disparities, fill vacancies and train teachers

By KAUSHIK DEKA



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Considering what the ruling BJP had promised in its election manifesto—universal, quality and future-ready education as envisioned by the New Education Policy, 2020—the education ministry pretty much knows what it has to do. The immediate priorities will have to bridging the learning gap in schools, making higher education industry-relevant and freeing entrance examinations of malpractices and glitches.

The ministry has already laid down certain tasks for its first 100 days: digitisation drive for effective monitoring of schools down to block level, standard assessment systems across school boards to check dropout levels, new courses to develop skills and more collaborations with foreign universities.

The key to achieving these goals will be through training teachers to align with the requirements of the NEP, adding infrastructure, facilitating use of technology and upgrading curriculums. Meanwhile, government schools continue to grapple with an array of challenges, adding to the divide between students from different socio-economic and geographic backgrounds. Despite the relatively better pace of development in the higher education infrastructure, there is little sign of big-ticket reforms even four years after the launch of the NEP. Meanwhile, policy's most significant recommendation—that budgetary allocation for education must touch around six per cent of the GDP—remains an unattainable target. ■

DHARMENDRA PRADHAN, *54* | BJP

Minister of Education

↘ **Promising start** Dharmendra Pradhan was born in Talcher, Odisha, in 1969 and became an ABVP activist as a student. He has a PG degree in anthropology from Utkal University and was elected to the Lok Sabha in 2004

↘ **Stellar poll show** He has returned to the Lok Sabha after 15 years. A Rajya Sabha member since 2012, Pradhan was instrumental in the BJP's winning 20 Lok Sabha seats in Odisha

↘ **Experienced hand** Pradhan has served in the Union cabinet earlier, handling the petroleum & natural gas, education and skill development ministries. His father Debendra Pradhan was MoS in the Atal Bihari Vajpayee government from 1999 to 2004

↘ **Education reforms** In his last outing as education minister, Pradhan oversaw ground-breaking reforms, particularly in the higher education sector, such as the Common University Entrance Test (CUET) for admission to undergraduate programmes in central universities and the Foreign Higher Education Institutions (FHEIs) policy that allows foreign universities to set up campus in India. PM Modi expects him to continue the reform agenda envisaged in NEP, 2020

↘ **LPG for poor** As minister of petroleum and natural gas, he supervised the Ujjwala Yojana, one of PM Modi's most ambitious projects, providing LPG connections to women from Below Poverty Line (BPL) families